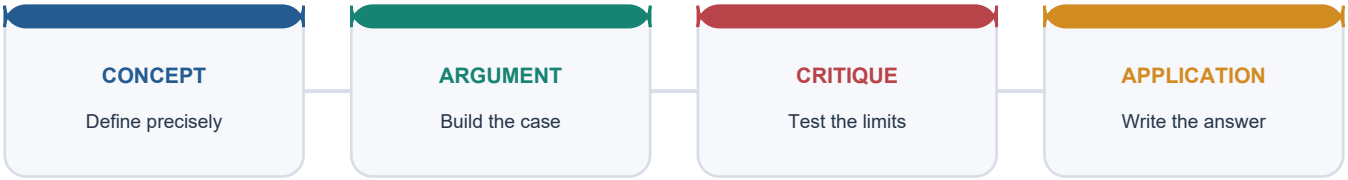
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Struggle for Empire: Afghans, Rajputs & Humayun - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Struggle for Empire: Afghans, Rajputs & Humayun - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Part I - 32 workbook MCQs with full option-wise explanations

Workbook MCQ 1

Question: A Timurid partition norm most directly complicated sovereignty by:

- A. making princely shares politically plausible even when the sovereign expected loyalty.
- B. placing Sher Khan in charge of Kabul.
- C. requiring every province to be formally independent.
- D. abolishing all royal claims.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Timurid custom could recognize one sovereign and still make princely territorial shares seem politically plausible, so exclusive centralized sovereignty remained under pressure.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sher Khan belongs to Bihar-Chunar politics, not to the Timurid division of Kabul among Babur's sons.
- **C.** Incorrect. Patrimonial sharing encouraged bargaining and quasi-partition, but it did not require every province to become a formally independent state.
- **D.** Incorrect. The norm weakened unified control; it did not abolish the ruler's superior claim to kingship, khutba or sikka.

Examiner trap: patrimony confused with the abolition of kingship

Workbook MCQ 2

Question: Kamran's retention of khutba and sikka in Humayun's name initially indicates:

- A. a completed union of all Mughal territory.
- B. formal acknowledgement alongside a de facto regional power position.
- C. a Safavid conquest of Punjab.
- D. a Rajput treaty at Chittor.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Khutba and sikka in Humayun's name preserved a formal imperial claim, but they did not prove that Kamran's Punjab power had dissolved into complete territorial unity.
- **B.** Correct. Kamran could exercise real regional authority while still acknowledging Humayun in the ceremonial language of sovereignty.
- **C.** Incorrect. No Safavid conquest of Punjab is at issue here; the point concerns Mughal fraternal politics within the Timurid house.
- **D.** Incorrect. Chittor belongs to the Rajput-Gujarat theatre, whereas khutba and sikka show Kamran's formal relation to Humayun.

Examiner trap: formal sovereignty mistaken for effective unity

Workbook MCQ 3

Question: The main value of the Dadrah/Daurah discrepancy for an answer is to:

- A. replace all evidence with a popular legend.
- B. make Nizamuddin Ahmad a contemporary eyewitness to every event.
- C. teach source method and date caution without abandoning the strategic narrative.

- D. deny that Humayun fought Afghans.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Source disagreement requires caution, but it does not permit replacing chronicle evidence with legend.
- **B.** Incorrect. Nizamuddin Ahmad was a later compiler with a compressed chronology; the issue is comparison of sources, not eyewitness certainty.
- **C.** Correct. The discrepancy teaches students to qualify precise dating while preserving the secure strategic reading of eastern Afghan pressure and Humayun's response.
- **D.** Incorrect. The campaigns remain historically secure; what is disputed is the exact ordering of Dadrah/Daurah and Chunar, not the existence of the Afghan challenge.

Examiner trap: chronology caution inflated into total uncertainty

Workbook MCQ 4

Question: Kalinjar belongs to the early phase because it:

- A. marked restoration in 1555.
- B. was captured by Sher Khan after Gaur.
- C. was a port on the Gujarat coast.
- D. formed part of a southern defensive-fort setting around Agra and preceded the Chunar episode.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. 1555 belongs to Humayun's restoration after exile, whereas Kalinjar sits in the accession-period consolidation sequence.
- **B.** Incorrect. Gaur and Sher Khan's Bengal phase came much later than the Kalinjar-Chunar stage.
- **C.** Incorrect. Kalinjar was an inland Bundelkhand fort, not a port on the Gujarat coast.
- **D.** Correct. In the assigned sequence, Kalinjar forms part of the southern defensive-fort setting around Agra and precedes the Chunar episode.

Examiner trap: Kalinjar and the eastern phase detached from strategic sequencing

Workbook MCQ 5

Question: At the first Chunar accommodation, Humayun's calculation was that:

- A. Sher Khan was not yet a sufficient danger to require a Bihar campaign, and an accommodation held tactical value.
- B. Chunar no longer mattered at all.
- C. Bahadur Shah would govern Bihar for him.
- D. the Mughal empire had already conquered Bengal.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Humayun accepted a tactical settlement because he had other fronts to watch and had not yet committed himself to a full Bihar campaign against Sher Khan.
- **B.** Incorrect. Chunar still mattered as an eastern route-fort; the accommodation shows limited prioritisation, not total indifference.
- **C.** Incorrect. Bahadur Shah was the western rival in Gujarat-Malwa, not a ruler who could administer Bihar on Humayun's behalf.
- **D.** Incorrect. Bengal had not already been conquered, which is why the eastern problem continued to grow.

Examiner trap: first Chunar accommodation narrated as simple blindness

Workbook MCQ 6

Question: Din Panah's location and timing most strongly support the view that it:

- A. was a Portuguese coastal enclave.
- B. used Delhi's prestige to frame a dynastic political project.
- C. was a private library unrelated to politics.
- D. replaced every previous Mughal centre overnight.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Din Panah was a Delhi political-city project, not a Portuguese coastal enclave.
- **B.** Correct. Founding Din Panah at Delhi used the prestige of the old imperial centre to frame Mughal kingship as a public dynastic project.
- **C.** Incorrect. Even if Humayun valued books and courtly culture, Din Panah cannot be reduced to a private library without political meaning.
- **D.** Incorrect. The project did not erase Agra or every older Mughal centre overnight; it expressed ambition more than accomplished reorganisation.

Examiner trap: Din Panah reduced to fantasy architecture

Workbook MCQ 7

Question: Bahadur Shah's power rested on:

- A. the dismantling of all Gujarati ports.
- B. only a small Afghan jagir near Jaunpur.
- C. Gujarat, Malwa acquisition, pressure toward Rajasthan and artillery resources in a western regional state.
- D. direct control of Kabul under Humayun.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Gujarat's commercial strength mattered because its ports existed and generated resources; Bahadur Shah's power did not rest on dismantling them.
- **B.** Incorrect. A tiny Afghan jagir near Jaunpur describes neither Bahadur Shah's resource base nor his west-Indian reach.
- **C.** Correct. Bahadur Shah combined Gujarat's wealth with Malwa, pressure toward Rajasthan and serious artillery-backed regional power.
- **D.** Incorrect. Kabul belonged to north-west Timurid politics, not to Bahadur Shah's power structure.

Examiner trap: Bahadur Shah treated as trivial side-show

Workbook MCQ 8

Question: A sound explanation for Humayun's stance near Chittor avoids:

- A. placing Malwa-Mewar-Gujarat in a strategic field.
- B. recognising Rajput resistance.
- C. linking eastern Rajasthan to the Agra-Delhi position.
- D. reducing the episode solely to a romanticised rakhi anecdote.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Any sound explanation should place Chittor inside the wider Malwa-Mewar-Gujarat strategic field.
- **B.** Incorrect. Recognising Rajput resistance is part of the explanation; the mistake lies in replacing strategy with legend.
- **C.** Incorrect. Eastern Rajasthan did matter because it affected the security of the Agra-Delhi core.

- **D.** Correct. The exam-safe move is to reject a purely rakhi-based reading and explain the regional power calculus instead.

Examiner trap: Chittor context replaced by legend or sentiment

Workbook MCQ 9

Question: At Mandsor, Humayun's response to Bahadur Shah's defended camp was to:

- A. avoid a frontal assault and squeeze supplies, exposing the limits of the camp's defensive plan.
- B. leave Malwa for Bengal immediately.
- C. attack blindly because artillery did not exist.
- D. appoint Sher Khan governor of Gujarat.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Humayun showed operational judgement at Mandsor by avoiding Bahadur Shah's prepared camp and pressing supplies instead of gifting the enemy a favourable artillery battle.
- **B.** Incorrect. The Bengal turn belonged later; at Mandsor Humayun was still contesting the western theatre.
- **C.** Incorrect. Artillery was central to Bahadur Shah's camp defence, which is exactly why a blind frontal assault was unattractive.
- **D.** Incorrect. Sher Khan was Humayun's eastern rival, not a Mughal governor placed over Gujarat.

Examiner trap: Mandsor logic confused with reckless frontal attack

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: The capture of Champaner demonstrates:

- A. the immediate creation of a stable Gujarat bureaucracy.
- B. a significant military success whose treasure could not substitute for political settlement.
- C. the automatic loyalty of every Gujarati noble.
- D. the end of Portuguese interest at Diu.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Seizing Champaner and its treasure did not automatically create a functioning provincial bureaucracy in Gujarat.
- **B.** Correct. Champaner was a real military success, but captured forts and treasure could not substitute for loyal officers, settlement and local political integration.
- **C.** Incorrect. Gujarati nobles did not become automatically loyal because one stronghold fell.
- **D.** Incorrect. Portuguese pressure around Diu remained relevant after the Gujarat campaign and later intersected with Bahadur Shah's death.

Examiner trap: one captured fort treated as durable province

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Askari's Gujarat assignment is important because it:

- A. makes Bengal a Mughal province.
- B. proves Askari never held any command.
- C. shows a formal attempt at direct administration that did not generate co-ordinated authority.
- D. defeated Sher Khan at Chausa.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Askari's Gujarat appointment says nothing about Bengal becoming a settled Mughal province.
- **B.** Incorrect. The point is the opposite: Askari did receive command, but that command failed to stabilise Gujarat.

- **C.** Correct. His assignment shows a formal Mughal attempt at provincial administration that did not generate durable co-ordination.
- **D.** Incorrect. Chausa belongs to the later Bihar-Bengal war with Sher Khan, not to Askari's Gujarat role.

Examiner trap: Askari blamed as sole cause of Gujarat failure

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: The phrase 'rootlessness of Mughal nobles' means:

- A. they were all born in Central Asia.
- B. they had no families anywhere.
- C. they had no military resources.
- D. their stronger attachment to the Delhi-Agra zone made distant Gujarat and Bengal administration unattractive.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Here 'rootlessness' is not an ethnic census of noble birthplaces; it describes weak attachment to distant Indian conquests.
- **B.** Incorrect. The phrase has nothing to do with nobles lacking households or kin.
- **C.** Incorrect. Mughal nobles clearly possessed military resources; the issue was their unwillingness to remain and administer far-off regions steadily.
- **D.** Correct. Satish Chandra uses the idea to explain why Gujarat and Bengal looked less attractive than the Delhi-Agra heartland to many Mughal officers.

Examiner trap: rootlessness read as ethnicity instead of administrative commitment

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Surajgarh belongs in Sher Khan's rise because it:

- A. helped Sher Khan break Bengal's pressure on Bihar and marked a higher political standing.
- B. occurred after Humayun's death.
- C. was a battle won by Humayun in Malwa.
- D. was a Portuguese naval action.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Surajgarh raised Sher Khan from a Bihar power-holder to a much larger contender by checking Bengal and enhancing prestige.
- **B.** Incorrect. Surajgarh belongs to 1534, long before Humayun's death in 1556.
- **C.** Incorrect. The battle is part of Sher Khan's Bihar-Bengal ascent, not a Mughal success in Malwa.
- **D.** Incorrect. Nothing in the event is maritime or Portuguese; it was an eastern land campaign.

Examiner trap: Surajgarh omitted from Sher Khan's rise

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: The best reading of Gaur in 1538 is:

- A. an Afghan camp with no Bengal context.
- B. Bengal's capital, whose seizure gave Sher Khan resources and changed the scale of the contest.
- C. a fort built by Humayun after 1555.
- D. a city without strategic or symbolic value.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Gaur was the Bengal capital, so stripping it of Bengal context removes the whole strategic point of Sher Khan's move.

- **B.** Correct. Taking Gaur brought treasure, prestige and strategic leverage, turning Sher Khan from a Bihar rival into a Bengal-scale challenger.
- **C.** Incorrect. Gaur was an old Bengal capital, not a city founded by Humayun after 1555.
- **D.** Incorrect. Precisely because Gaur had political and material value, its seizure changed the scale of the eastern contest.

Examiner trap: Gaur occupation mistaken for Bengal control

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Why did Humayun not simply bypass Chunar in 1537?

- A. Kamran demanded it as his residence.
- B. it stood in Rajasthan between Chittor and Mandu.
- C. A hostile fort could threaten communications during a Bengal advance.
- D. Bengal had already become loyal.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Chunar was not a residence demanded by Kamran; its importance lay in eastern campaign communications.
- **B.** Incorrect. The fort belonged to the route system toward Bihar, not to the Rajasthan theatre between Chittor and Mandu.
- **C.** Correct. Leaving a hostile Chunar in the rear could endanger the road-river links of a Bengal advance.
- **D.** Incorrect. Bengal was not a pacified loyal zone, which is why communications and siege choices mattered so much.

Examiner trap: Chunar bypass imagined as cost-free

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Sher Khan's offer regarding Bihar and Bengal demonstrates:

- A. that Humayun had already lost Kabul.
- B. his continued acceptance of a Mughal jagir only.
- C. the end of Afghan state-building.
- D. a negotiation between actors each imagining a wider political order, with Bengal as a central issue.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Kabul is unrelated to the bargaining issue here; the question concerns Sher Khan's eastern position in Bihar and Bengal.
- **B.** Incorrect. The offer matters precisely because Sher Khan was thinking beyond the subordinate place of an ordinary jagirdar.
- **C.** Incorrect. Negotiation over Bihar and Bengal does not mark the end of Afghan state-building; it shows its growing ambition.
- **D.** Correct. The proposal reveals two large political imaginations colliding: Sher Khan sought recognised eastern authority, while Humayun envisaged Bengal inside wider imperial unity.

Examiner trap: Sher Khan's offer read as proof of subordination

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Humayun's stay at Gaur could not solve the Bengal problem because:

- A. officers' lack of commitment, horse losses, distance and broken communications undermined administration.
- B. Bengal lacked any local population.
- C. Chittor remained unconquered.
- D. no one could travel by river.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Distance from Agra, weak administrative commitment, horse losses and broken rear communications made Gaur an exposed occupation rather than a secure settlement.
- **B.** Incorrect. Bengal's population was never the issue; the problem was governing the province under hostile strategic conditions.
- **C.** Incorrect. Chittor belonged to the western theatre and had nothing to do with why Gaur became untenable.
- **D.** Incorrect. River travel existed, but river-monsoon conditions complicated movement instead of making it impossible.

Examiner trap: distance narrated without communications logic

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: Hindal's move at Agra during the Bengal phase shows:

- A. that Kamran was never politically active.
- B. how elite defections and a princely bid compounded a campaign already stretched eastward.
- C. the earliest cause of the 1530 inheritance.
- D. a Portuguese intervention in the north.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Hindal's move does not erase Kamran's wider role; it shows that the crisis involved multiple princely actors.
- **B.** Correct. Hindal's Agra bid mattered because it encouraged elite defection at the moment Humayun was already overstretched in Bengal.
- **C.** Incorrect. This disturbance belongs to the Bengal-phase crisis, not to the inherited conditions of 1530.
- **D.** Incorrect. The episode concerns Mughal princely politics at Agra, not Portuguese intervention.

Examiner trap: Hindal's rear move projected backward as the origin of all crisis

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: Chausa should be analysed as:

- A. a proof that no Mughal force reached Bihar.
- B. a decisive 1540 restoration victory.
- C. a battle where position, surprise, command and campaign exhaustion converged.
- D. a naval battle at Diu.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Humayun had already campaigned in Bihar and Bengal, so Chausa cannot mean that no Mughal force reached the east.
- **B.** Incorrect. Chausa was Sher Khan's 1539 victory, not a Mughal restoration in 1540.
- **C.** Correct. The safest analysis joins exposed position near the Karmnasa, surprise attack, campaign strain and command failure.
- **D.** Incorrect. Diu is a western maritime setting, whereas Chausa was a Gangetic land-river battle against Sher Khan.

Examiner trap: Chausa merged with later expulsion

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: The distinct significance of Kannauj/Bilgram is that it:

- A. settled Gujarat's administration.

- B. was fought before Chausa.
- C. brought Shah Tahmasp to Delhi.
- D. converted the prior shock into a decisive Afghan victory that displaced Humayun from north India.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Kannauj/Bilgram did not settle Gujarat; it decided the Mughal-Afghan struggle for north India.
- **B.** Incorrect. The chronology runs the other way: Chausa came in 1539 and Kannauj followed in 1540.
- **C.** Incorrect. Shah Tahmasp's aid belongs to the exile-and-recovery story after Humayun lost north India.
- **D.** Correct. Kannauj turned earlier damage into final displacement because Humayun fought with a weakened, hastily assembled force and lost the core region.

Examiner trap: Kannauj treated as repetition without fresh political effect

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Kamran's hardened troops matter especially because:

- A. their non-availability after Chausa deprived Humayun of a significant reinforcement in the decisive phase.
- B. they were stationed at Gaur under Hindal.
- C. they supplied Humayun at Chausa without conditions.
- D. they fought for Bahadur Shah at Mandu.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. After Chausa, the absence of Kamran's seasoned troops mattered because Humayun entered the decisive phase without a reinforcement that could stiffen his army.
- **B.** Incorrect. Those hardened troops were associated with Kamran's north-western position, not with Hindal at Gaur.
- **C.** Incorrect. The point of the source is their non-availability, not their ready service to Humayun.
- **D.** Incorrect. They matter to Mughal fraternal politics after Chausa, not to Bahadur Shah's Gujarat campaign.

Examiner trap: Kamran's troops ignored in the final phase

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: A fair reading of the brothers is:

- A. their conduct has no relation to state structure.
- B. their roles changed across time; rivalry interacted with campaign stress, legitimacy and noble calculation.
- C. they determined Bahadur Shah's Portuguese policy.
- D. all were either heroes or traitors throughout.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The brothers operated inside a patrimonial Timurid order, so their conduct cannot be detached from state structure.
- **B.** Correct. Kamran, Askari and Hindal mattered differently at different moments; rivalry, logistics, legitimacy and noble calculation changed the weight of each role.
- **C.** Incorrect. Bahadur Shah's dealings with the Portuguese belong to Gujarat's external politics, not to the interpretation of the brothers.
- **D.** Incorrect. A timeless hero-versus-traitor story ignores chronology and the mixed record of service, delegation and defection.

Examiner trap: brothers turned into timeless villains

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: The exile in Sindh underscores that:

- A. Humayun controlled every regional ruler.
- B. Sher Shah granted Humayun Bengal.
- C. regional rulers such as Sindh's authorities and Maldeo did not automatically risk themselves for a fallen Mughal.
- D. Iran was irrelevant to recovery.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Exile shows the opposite: Humayun could not command automatic obedience from regional rulers once he had lost power.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sher Shah was Humayun's conqueror, not a benefactor who restored Bengal to him.
- **C.** Correct. Sindh, Marwar and neighbouring rulers calculated their own risks, which reveals how thin Mughal support became after defeat.
- **D.** Incorrect. Iranian assistance became crucial precisely because subcontinental sanctuary and support were so limited.

Examiner trap: exile told as lonely romance instead of negotiated refuge

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Safavid help under Shah Tahmasp should be presented as:

- A. a literary legend with no recovery outcome.
- B. an entirely religious crusade with no frontier politics.
- C. a direct annexation of Delhi by Iran.
- D. a consequential political alliance whose terms and sectarian dimensions require precise sourcing.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Shah Tahmasp's help had real consequences in the recovery of Qandahar and Kabul.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sectarian issues may enter some narratives, but reducing the episode to a pure religious crusade strips away frontier politics and diplomatic bargaining.
- **C.** Incorrect. Safavid support did not annex Delhi to Iran; Humayun used it to rebuild his own position in the north-west.
- **D.** Correct. This is the exam-safe presentation: emphasise political aid and recovery, then qualify any disputed conditions or sectarian details by source.

Examiner trap: Safavid aid reduced to miracle or total conversion

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: The 1545 recovery of Qandahar and Kabul provided:

- A. a north-western base from which a later return became possible.
- B. the elimination of Sur factions in Delhi.
- C. a restoration of Gujarat through Askari.
- D. instant control of all north India.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Recovering Qandahar and Kabul restored a viable north-western base, without which the later return to India would have been impossible.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sur power in Delhi lasted beyond 1545; that recovery occurred on the frontier, not in the Indo-Gangetic core.

- **C.** Incorrect. Askari's Gujarat role belonged to the failed 1530s western occupation, not to the 1545 north-west recovery.
- **D.** Incorrect. Qandahar and Kabul gave Humayun a base, not immediate rule over all north India.

Examiner trap: Qandahar-Kabul recovery treated as final stability

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Sur fragmentation matters in 1555 because it:

- A. was caused by the 1535 Champaner siege.
- B. created openings that Humayun could exploit in regaining Delhi.
- C. proves Sher Shah never had a state.
- D. made Afghanistan irrelevant.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The 1550s Sur fragmentation was not caused by the old Champaner campaign of 1535.
- **B.** Correct. Humayun's return succeeded not only because he had rebuilt strength, but because the Sur polity had split and opened room for recovery.
- **C.** Incorrect. A later dynastic breakdown does not erase the reality of Sher Shah's earlier state-building.
- **D.** Incorrect. Afghanistan remained relevant because Humayun's restored strength still rested on the Qandahar-Kabul base.

Examiner trap: Sur fragmentation omitted from the 1555 explanation

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Humayun's death in 1556 is historically significant because:

- A. it took place before Chausa.
- B. it ended the Mughal line.
- C. the restored dynasty passed into Akbar's accession crisis rather than becoming a settled personal rule.
- D. it transferred Delhi to Bahadur Shah.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Humayun died in 1556 after restoration, not before the 1539 Chausa defeat.
- **B.** Incorrect. The Mughal line continued under Akbar.
- **C.** Correct. His death matters because restoration had barely been secured when succession passed into Akbar's precarious early phase rather than a long settled Humayun reign.
- **D.** Incorrect. Bahadur Shah had died long earlier, so Humayun's death did not transfer Delhi to Gujarat.

Examiner trap: library-fall anecdote replacing political significance

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which formulation rejects the opium caricature without exonerating Humayun?

- A. He made no serious error.
- B. His private habits mechanically decided every battle.
- C. Sher Khan had no role in the outcome.
- D. Campaign energy in Gujarat coexisted with poor sequencing, administrative limits and serious misjudgement of Sher Khan.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. This turns correction into acquittal by pretending Humayun made no serious errors.

- **B.** Incorrect. A private-habit caricature is too mechanical; it cannot replace campaign sequence, logistics, brothers and Sher Khan's ability.
- **C.** Incorrect. Any balanced explanation must preserve Sher Khan as a major historical actor.
- **D.** Correct. This formulation keeps Humayun's misjudgements in view while rejecting a single-cause moral caricature.

Examiner trap: rehabilitation turned into exoneration

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: A source-critical hierarchy would treat:

- A. Nizamuddin's compressed chronology, later Mughal narratives and regional traditions as sources with different reach and limits.
- B. a later popular legend as superior to all contemporary evidence.
- C. a monument as direct proof of every sixteenth-century political event.
- D. all Mughal chronicles as identical.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. A sound hierarchy distinguishes between Nizamuddin's compressed chronology, later Mughal reconstructions and regional traditions instead of treating them as one type of evidence.
- **B.** Incorrect. Later popular memory can be useful, but it cannot outrank all contemporary or near-contemporary evidence by default.
- **C.** Incorrect. A monument or UNESCO description may illuminate memory and architecture, not troop movement or every sixteenth-century political event.
- **D.** Incorrect. Mughal chronicles differ in date, purpose, patronage and detail, so source criticism cannot flatten them into sameness.

Examiner trap: memoir and chronicle ranked without provenance control

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: UNESCO's Humayun's Tomb description is useful in this package only as:

- A. proof that Karnavati sent a rakhi.
- B. a bounded modern heritage anchor for dynastic memory, garden-tomb form and conservation.
- C. evidence for the troop position at Chausa.
- D. a replacement for early Mughal chronicles.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A modern heritage description cannot prove the Karnavati-rakhi story.
- **B.** Correct. In this topic the UNESCO page is used narrowly: as a modern heritage anchor for dynastic memory, tomb-garden form and conservation, not as campaign evidence.
- **C.** Incorrect. A heritage note on Humayun's Tomb cannot establish battlefield deployment at Chausa.
- **D.** Incorrect. Chronicles remain necessary for sixteenth-century politics; UNESCO is a bounded supplementary aid, not a replacement archive.

Examiner trap: Humayun's Tomb used as campaign evidence

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: The most accurate meaning of 'unfinished conquest' in this topic is:

- A. A completed Bengal revenue survey.
- B. A permanent settlement with every Afghan chief.
- C. A political gain without fully rooted fiscal-administrative control.
- D. A dynasty with no territorial centre at all.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A completed Bengal revenue survey belongs to a far later administrative completeness than the topic's opening condition.
- **B.** Incorrect. Afghan resistance remained active, so no permanent settlement with every chief existed.
- **C.** Correct. 'Unfinished conquest' means victories had created a core but not a securely rooted fiscal-administrative order across the newly claimed empire.
- **D.** Incorrect. Babur did leave a territorial centre in Delhi-Agra; the problem was fragility, not total absence.

Examiner trap: inheritance flattened into either emptiness or complete stability

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Babur's late fiscal difficulty matters to Humayun because it:

- A. gave Gujarat to Bahadur Shah.
- B. made Chunar inaccessible by river.
- C. ended the need to pay begs.
- D. left an already stretched treasury beside a large military-political task.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Bahadur Shah's rise in Gujarat had its own western causes; Babur's fiscal strain did not simply hand him the province.
- **B.** Incorrect. Chunar's geography did not change because Babur's treasury was weak.
- **C.** Incorrect. Financial strain made rewarding and maintaining begs harder, not unnecessary.
- **D.** Correct. Humayun inherited a stretched treasury at the same time that he had to manage nobles, brothers and multiple regional rivals.

Examiner trap: fiscal strain turned into a single-cause campaign answer

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Direct PYQ ownership audit

The canonical Basic and Advanced Topic 13 owners were rechecked first. They route **zero direct UPSC Civil Services PYQs to Topic 13 for 2018-2026**, and no exact Humayun-owned prelims wording is locally secure enough to reproduce from the adjacent Gujarat route. That gap is preserved honestly here.

Transparent routed / adjacent support items

All four retained support items below are explicitly **adjacent or routed support PYQs**, not relabelled direct Topic 13 ownership claims. They are kept because they sharpen chronology discipline, source method and military-technology reasoning relevant to Topic 13.

Adjacent PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 chronology route (wording verified locally; key inferred)

Question as securely verified from local OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option-row status: The local OCR preserves the combination row imperfectly, but earlier validated repository usage supports the standard set containing "1 only", "1 and 2", "3 only" and "2 and 3".

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

How to think it through: Statement 1 is correct because Chinggis Khan reached the Indus in 1221 during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's Indian invasion belongs to 1398, far after Muhammad bin Tughluq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, long after Deva Raya II. For Topic 13, this route matters only as chronology discipline: if earlier medieval dates are blurred, the Humayun-Sher Khan sequence also becomes easy to misplace.

Demand decoding: This is a chronology-elimination question. In Topic 13, its use is bounded: keep pre-Mughal medieval anchors clear so 1530-1556 chronology is not written against a blurred background.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Test each statement independently by ruler and date; once Statements 2 and 3 fail, the combination narrows to "1 only".

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It shows exact chronological elimination and honestly preserves the inferred-key status instead of pretending to hold an official local answer row.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the year 1398 explicitly when rejecting Timur so north-west frontier chronology becomes even harder to confuse with sixteenth-century Mughal events.

Adjacent PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 frontier chronology route (wording verified locally; key inferred)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 2
- B. 2 only
- C. 1 and 3
- D. 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: B. 2 only. Confidence: high.

How to think it through: Statement 1 falls because Mongol pressure on India predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 stands because Alauddin's reign did face a major Mongol assault that reached Delhi. Statement 3 is not retained in the secure repository route, so the safe answer remains B. For Topic 13, this item works only as adjacent frontier chronology and should not be relabelled as a Humayun PYQ.

Demand decoding: Answer statement-by-statement and keep earlier frontier chronology separate from the later Humayun-Afghan struggle.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Reject Statement 1 first on chronology, preserve Statement 2, then treat Statement 3 cautiously within the already-audited repository route before choosing B.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks by separating earlier Mongol frontier pressure from later Mughal chronology instead of collapsing all north-west crises together.

How to improve/strengthen: Name Alauddin Khalji directly in the elimination line so the accepted statement is anchored to a ruler, not merely to a period label.

Routed PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-I 2020 source-method support

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Persian literary sources are indispensable because they preserve kingship, conquest, morality and courtly self-presentation; yet they reflect the age only when read with genre caution. For Topic 13, the most transferable examples are Gulbadan Begum's *Humayun-nama*, later Mughal chronicles such as the *Akbarnama* and compilations like *Tabaqat-i Akbari*, together with Afghan memory texts such as Sarwani's *Tarikh-i Sher Shahi*. These works reveal household politics, exile, kingship, diplomacy and the political language of the sixteenth century, but none is a transparent mirror. Gulbadan is retrospective and family-centred, official chronicles carry dynastic teleology, and Afghan narratives have their own retrospective admiration. Hence Persian literary texts reflect the age in a refracted way. Their greatest value lies in showing elite assumptions, political vocabulary and remembered crisis, while coins, forts, inscriptions and chronology control provide the needed check. For Topic 13, the safest lesson is to

use memoir and chronicle boldly for perspective, but never as untested final authority.

Demand decoding: Treat this as a source-method question: explain value and limitation together, then show how *Humayun-nama* and later chronicles illuminate Topic 13 without exhausting it.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Open with the value-limitation thesis, move to Gulbadan and later Persian/Afghan texts as named evidence, then close with corroboration through material and chronological checks.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It turns a general Persian-source demand into a precise Humayun-era evidence lesson without pretending that the question is Topic 13-owned.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one sentence naming what coins, khutba or fort occupation can show so the non-literary corroboration rule appears even more sharply.

Routed PYQ 4 - UPSC GS-I 2023 technology route

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: The Sultanate mattered technologically because it accelerated the spread and systematisation of techniques in architecture, warfare and administration. Topic 13 borrows this route only for the military and communication angle. By Humayun's time, firearms, fortified positions, route-forts and mobile command had become more consequential in north Indian warfare, but Chausa and Kannauj show that technology mattered only when joined to logistics and organisation. Chunar's strategic value lay in route control, while Sher Khan's success depended on intelligence, movement and communications as much as on armed force. The larger social effect of such technological change lay in state capacity: stronger siege work, more demanding military coordination and sharper pressure on revenue and supply. Yet this must not be romanticised as automatic progress. Technology strengthened states and commanders unevenly, and in Topic 13 superior political organisation still mattered more than the mere possession of guns or forts. The best borrowed lesson is that early Mughal-Afghan warfare belongs to a wider history of changing military techniques, but cannot be reduced to hardware alone.

Demand decoding: Use the question as a technology-plus-society prompt, then borrow Chunar, communications and battlefield organisation only as bounded examples relevant to Topic 13.

Executable answer/elimination plan: List broader technological fields quickly, then narrow to eastern route-forts, firearms and command so the answer remains tied to the verified question.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it keeps the topic within its proper boundary: Topic 13 can illuminate state capacity and warfare without pretending to own the full Sultanate technology question.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one short phrase distinguishing fort, firearm and communication technology so the borrowed Topic 13 examples appear as a subset of the larger medieval change.

Original solved Mains questions

Exactly six original Mains models are retained below: **2 x 10 marks**, **2 x 15 marks**, **2 x 20 marks**.

Original Mains 1 - Examine the proposition that Humayun inherited an unfinished conquest. (10 marks; 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Humayun inherited a conquest rather than a settled empire. Babur's victories had created a Delhi-Agra core, but the state that passed in December 1530 remained financially and administratively thin.

Named evidence and analysis. First, the local Satish Chandra account notes stretched finances after Babur had exhausted the Lodi treasure and sought a share from assigned revenues. That evidence matters because war, rewards and office-holding required a dependable fiscal base; a victory treasury was not a routine revenue system. Second, the administration relied heavily on begs holding large assignments. Such delegation could mobilise men, yet it also made local authority and collection dependent on followers whose interests were not automatically identical with the centre. Third, eastern Afghans remained politically active from east Uttar Pradesh to Bihar, while Sher Khan had access to Chunar. This shows that Panipat and Ghaghra had not dissolved Afghan political capacity.

Qualification. The inheritance was not empty. Humayun had Delhi-Agra prestige, military resources and scope for action, as Dadrah and Gujarat later show. Nor should Kamran's position be presented as an instant terminal fracture: it relieved Humayun of some north-western burdens before becoming acute in the later crisis.

Conclusion. The phrase 'unfinished conquest' therefore means a mismatch between territorial claim and institutional depth. It explains vulnerability without denying agency: Humayun still had to choose priorities, and Sher Khan still had to build an alternative coalition.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Mains 1. Examine the proposition that Humayun inherited an unfinished conquest.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It defines the proposition, deploys fiscal, administrative and Afghan evidence, and ends with a qualified causal verdict rather than a personality label.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 1. Examine the proposition that Humayun inherited an unfinished conquest.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 2 - Evaluate Humayun's Gujarat campaign. (10 marks; 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. The Gujarat campaign was a serious military achievement but an administrative failure; either half of that judgement is inadequate.

Evidence and analysis. Bahadur Shah's Gujarat-Malwa power and pressure around Chittor made the western theatre strategically relevant to Delhi-Agra. In 1535 Humayun moved through eastern Malwa, held a position near Ujjain/Mandsor, and avoided the frontal attack that Bahadur Shah's artillery-backed camp invited. By cutting supplies, he compelled withdrawal; Mandu, Champaner and later Ahmedabad fell. These named stages demonstrate drive, operational patience and personal courage, not passivity.

The holding problem was different. Humayun gave Askari overall responsibility and divided Gujarat among nobles, yet no durable revenue or co-ordination system emerged. Begs who regarded the Delhi-Agra region as home were reluctant to remain in Gujarat; suspicions between Askari and commanders deepened the failure. Bahadur Shah's recovery and regional reassertion followed. Humayun's own slow intervention from Mandu and later fear about Askari compounded the breakdown.

Qualification. The loss should not be described as a simple popular revolt or as proof that the campaign achieved nothing. It removed Bahadur Shah as an immediate northern threat; his subsequent death in a Portuguese-related fracas further reduced that danger.

Conclusion. Gujarat shows the central lesson of the topic: battle success without administrative settlement becomes a temporary occupation.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Mains 4. Evaluate Humayun's Gujarat campaign.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It separates campaign from governance, supplies named military evidence, and qualifies both the failure and the achievement.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 4. Evaluate Humayun's Gujarat campaign.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 3 - Discuss the Afghan challenge under Sher Khan as a political-military alternative. (15 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sher Khan was not simply a rebellious jagirdar who happened to defeat an emperor. By the late 1530s he represented an alternative north-Indian political project, built from a Bihar base, Afghan networks, Bengal resources and superior strategic adaptation.

Evidence and mechanism. Chunar gave Sher Khan a strong eastern position, while the Afghan field extended across east Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. The earlier Mughal-Afghan contest had already shown that these regions contained mobile leaders and sanctuaries. Sher Khan's victory at Surajgarh in 1534 against Bengal pressure strengthened his Bihar position; the subsequent seizure of Gaur enlarged his resource and symbolic reach. The reported offer to leave Bihar and remit revenue if Bengal were confirmed to him is analytically revealing: it treats Bengal as a sovereign-scale prize, not as an office held at imperial pleasure.

At Chausa, Sher Khan exploited Humayun's exposed posture; at Kannauj/Bilgram he led the force that decisively expelled the Mughals from north India. These were not accidents of ethnic identity. They joined leadership, regional roots, intelligence, movement, terrain and an ability to gather Afghan support under a credible command.

Qualification. Afghan politics were not permanently uniform: chiefs had differing interests, and no timeless 'tribal' essence explains success. Mughal errors-especially the Bengal communications problem and later fractured command-enlarged the opportunity. Detailed Sur administrative reforms belong to the following topic and should not be pre-dated here.

Conclusion. Sher Khan's strength lay in converting a regional Afghan social-military field into a state-building coalition at the exact moment Mughal expansion exceeded its administrative base.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 3. Discuss the Afghan challenge under Sher Khan as a political-military alternative.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It replaces a stereotype with concrete evidence, distinguishes political scale from office-holding, and respects the Topic 14 boundary.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 3. Discuss the Afghan challenge under Sher Khan as a political-military alternative.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 4 - Compare Chausa and Kannauj/Bilgram in the collapse of Humayun's first reign. (15 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Chausa and Kannauj/Bilgram form a sequence, not duplicate names for one defeat: the first exposed operational weakness and shattered confidence; the second made Mughal displacement from north India decisive.

Chausa, 26 June 1539. Humayun had returned from Bengal through a field in which Sher Khan had pressed communications back toward Agra. At Chausa he kept the Karmnasa at his back, deployed badly and allowed surprise. The named river position matters because it restricted retreat; Sher Khan's initiative matters because a poor position alone does not win a battle for the opponent. Humayun escaped, so Chausa did not itself finish Mughal rule.

Kannauj/Bilgram, 17 May 1540. The later battle was fought after morale, time and command had deteriorated. Kamran had 10,000 hardened troops but would not put them under Humayun's command after Chausa, and then withdrew toward Lahore. Humayun's force was hastily assembled; Sher Khan was the better-prepared Afghan commander. The result was decisive expulsion from north India.

Comparison. Both battles belong to the Bengal-Afghan strategic crisis and reveal the effect of fractured Mughal co-operation. Yet Chausa should not be narrated as Kannauj in advance: it was a tactical disaster with survival; Kannauj was the political decision.

Qualification. It is wrong to make Kamran the cause of Chausa, since the operational error and Sher Khan's command were already present. It is equally wrong to omit Kamran from the final phase, where the unavailable hardened troops mattered materially.

Conclusion. The pair shows how tactical error, rival capacity and post-defeat political fragmentation can turn a reversible shock into regime collapse.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires a direct position on "Mains 6. Compare Chausa and Kannauj/Bilgram in the collapse of Humayun's first reign.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It uses dates, battlefield mechanism and force condition, then makes a true comparison rather than two disconnected mini-narratives.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 6. Compare Chausa and Kannauj/Bilgram in the collapse of Humayun's first reign.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 5 - Assess Humayun's exile and Safavid assistance as a phase of political recovery. (20 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Exile after 1540 exposed the limits of Mughal prestige without a territorial base, while Safavid assistance showed how frontier diplomacy could rebuild that base. Neither episode should be reduced to an adventure story or a simple religious conversion narrative.

Loss and regional difficulty. After Kannauj, Humayun and his brothers could not agree on a strategy. Kamran prioritised Kabul; Humayun moved toward Sindh and explored a Gujarat route. The local source records years of wandering in which the rulers of Sindh and Maldeo of Marwar were unwilling to stake themselves on a fallen claimant with limited resources. This is political evidence: regional rulers calculated risk, capacity and survival rather than responding automatically to Timurid status.

Safavid connection and recovery. Humayun eventually took shelter with Shah Tahmasp of Iran. Safavid support enabled the recapture of Qandahar and then Kabul in 1545. Qandahar and Kabul mattered not merely as refuges: together they provided a north-western political and military base, a connection to Iranian-Central Asian diplomacy, and a platform from which later recovery could be imagined.

Source and religious caution. Political and religious conditions attached to the Safavid relationship must be stated only with source precision. The evidence safely supports a consequential alliance and aid; an unqualified assertion of a simple, permanently forced conversion flattens complex court and diplomatic circumstances. Similarly, later Mughal chronicles have dynastic purposes and should be read alongside their chronology limits.

Qualification. External help did not by itself restore Delhi. The recovery of 1555 depended also on fragmentation within the Sur order. Conversely, Sur fragmentation does not make the Safavid bridge irrelevant: without the Kabul-Qandahar base, a return remained far harder.

Conclusion. Exile transformed Humayun from a dispossessed claimant into a ruler rebuilding resources through diplomacy and frontier recovery. It is a political recovery phase, not a narrative interlude.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Mains 9. Assess Humayun's exile and Safavid assistance as a phase of political recovery.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It uses Sindh, Maldeo, Shah Tahmasp, Qandahar and Kabul as evidence, addresses religious caution directly, and links aid to the later restoration without monocausality.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 9. Assess Humayun's exile and Safavid assistance as a phase of political recovery.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 6 - Explain the significance and limits of Humayun's restoration in 1555. (20 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Humayun's recovery of Delhi in 1555 was historically significant because it restored the Mughal dynastic foothold, but it was enabled by Sur fragmentation and did not cancel the earlier evidence of institutional fragility.

Why restoration was possible. The Sur order that had displaced Humayun after Kannauj did not remain politically unified. This fragmentation opened a field that Humayun, now backed by the Kabul-Qandahar base recovered after Safavid assistance, could exploit. Delhi recovery therefore depended on a convergence of external recovery, opponent fragmentation and renewed Mughal agency. It was not a simple replay of the 1530 inheritance.

Why it mattered. Delhi carried accumulated imperial prestige; its recovery restored a political centre and made the Mughal line viable at the moment before Akbar's accession. The later architectural memory of Humayun's Tomb-UNESCO describes a grand 1560s garden-tomb patronised by Akbar-can be used only to illustrate dynastic memorialisation and a restored imperial language. It is not evidence that the first reign's campaigns had been successful.

Limits and continuity. The period 1530-40 had revealed weak finances, unrooted nobles, insecure communications, Timurid fraternal competition and the force of an Afghan alternative under Sher Khan. A Delhi recovery did not retrospectively solve those problems. Humayun died in 1556, leaving Akbar an opening rather than a completed institutional achievement. Akbar consolidated a restored foundation; later Mughal capacities did not already exist in 1555.

Qualification. Restoration nevertheless refutes a terminal-failure thesis. Humayun showed resilience, diplomatic adaptability and an ability to regain a centre after a profound defeat. The historical verdict must therefore hold collapse and recovery together.

Conclusion. 1555 marks dynastic rehabilitation, not the erasure of 1540. Its significance lies precisely in preserving a fragile opening through which a later, more durable Mughal consolidation became possible.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Mains 10. Explain the significance and limits of Humayun's restoration in 1555.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable answer/elimination plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It treats restoration causally, bounds heritage evidence and transitions to Akbar.

How to improve/strengthen: For "Mains 10. Explain the significance and limits of Humayun's restoration in 1555.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.